

# THE ZERO TRIMESTER

Your 90-Day Preconception Guide for Couples

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*"Don't just conceive, preconceive." -- Dr. Rajeev Agarwal*

Your baby's health doesn't begin at week one of pregnancy. It begins in the 90 days before conception -- the Zero Trimester -- when eggs and sperm are maturing, hormones are being set, and your nutritional reserves are being built. This guide covers what every couple should address before the first attempt to conceive.

## FOR HER -- what she should address before trying

### SUPPLEMENTS TO START TODAY

- Folic acid 400-800 mcg daily -- start now
- Vitamin B12 -- especially if vegetarian
- Vitamin D 1000-2000 IU daily
- Iron -- if haemoglobin is below 12 g/dL

### ESSENTIAL BLOOD TESTS

- Haemoglobin and ferritin
- Thyroid -- TSH should be below 2.5
- PP 75g glucose load (insulin resistance)
- HOMA-IR if insulin resistance is suspected
- Rubella IgG -- confirm immunity
- Varicella IgG -- check if unsure
- Hepatitis B surface antigen
- AMH -- for all couples planning pregnancy

### GENETIC SCREENING

- HPLC or haemoglobin electrophoresis (thalassaemia)
- If thalassaemia carrier -- partner must be tested
- SMA -- MLPA genetic carrier screening

### GYNAECOLOGICAL ASSESSMENT

- Pelvic ultrasound -- uterus, ovaries, AFC
- PCOS or endometriosis -- address before
- Cervical smear if it is due

### VACCINATIONS TO CONFIRM

- Rubella -- 1 dose if not immune
- Varicella -- 2 doses if never had it
- Hepatitis B -- complete 3-dose course
- Influenza -- annually recommended

### MEDICAL AND MEDICATION REVIEW

- Review all current medications with doctor

### A NOTE FROM DR. RAJEEV AGARWAL

*Most couples come to me after months of trying -- sometimes years. What I wish every couple knew earlier is this: pregnancy is not a moment, it is a preparation. The choices you make in the 90 days before conception shape your child's health in ways that begin before the first missed period. Come in early. Come in together. Let us make a plan.*

## FOR HIM -- his health matters equally

### SEMEN ANALYSIS

- Count, motility and morphology
- DNA fragmentation index if needed
- 3-5 days abstinence before sample

### LIFESTYLE AND HABITS

- Stop smoking -- damages sperm DNA directly
- Alcohol -- zero, even while trying to conceive
- No laptop on lap -- heat affects sperm
- No anabolic steroids or recreational drugs
- Avoid tight underwear if count is low

### METABOLIC AND GENERAL HEALTH

- Maintain healthy weight (BMI 18.5-25)
- Fasting blood glucose and blood pressure
- Thalassaemia test if her result is positive
- Review all medications with your doctor

### SUPPLEMENTS FOR HIM

- Folic acid -- reduces sperm DNA errors
- Zinc, selenium and antioxidants (CoQ10)
- Vitamin D if blood levels are low

### SLEEP, STRESS AND ENVIRONMENT

- Manage stress -- cortisol suppresses sperm
- Sleep 7-8 hours and before midnight
- Quit shisha or hookah -- as bad as cigarettes
- Minimise exposure to pesticides and plastics

## Book a consultation

WhatsApp / Call: +91 62922 69060  
drrajeevagarwal.co.in/preconception

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## AS A COUPLE

-- shared steps that make the biggest difference

## DIET AND NUTRITION

- Eat wholesome meals -- not just supplements
- Folate-rich: leafy greens, lentils, citrus
- Antioxidants daily: berries, nuts, vegetables
- Limit processed food, sugar and trans fats
- Protein daily: eggs, legumes, fish, dairy

## ALCOHOL AND SMOKING

- No safe level of alcohol near conception
- Alcohol harms both egg and sperm quality
- Both partners should stop smoking now
- Passive smoke exposure is equally harmful

## WEIGHT AND EXERCISE

- Aim for BMI 18.5-25 before conceiving
- 5% weight loss can restore ovulation in PCOS
- Moderate exercise: 30 min, 5 days a week
- Avoid crash diets or rapid weight changes

## WHAT TO LIMIT OR AVOID

- Caffeine: under 200 mg per day (2 cups)
- Endocrine disruptors: plastics, non-stick
- Raw or undercooked meat (toxoplasmosis)
- X-ray or radiation without shielding

## CHRONIC CONDITIONS TO OPTIMISE

- Diabetes: optimise HbA1c before conceiving
- Thyroid: TSH should be below 2.5 mIU/L
- Hypertension: medication review needed
- Epilepsy: valproate requires review first

## SLEEP AND STRESS

- Chronic stress suppresses ovulation
- Cortisol disrupts LH release in both sexes
- Aim for 7-8 hours sleep, before midnight
- Yoga and meditation -- evidence supports both

## FERTILE WINDOW AND TIMING

- Ovulation: around day 14 in 28-day cycle
- Use ovulation predictor kits if unsure
- Intercourse every 2-3 days is sufficient
- Daily intercourse is not more effective

## OFTEN OVERLOOKED

- Dental health: gum disease links to preterm
- Gut health: affects nutrient absorption
- Mental health: seek support early if needed
- Dental treatment is safest before pregnancy

## WHEN TO SEEK YOUR CONSULTATION EARLIER -- DO NOT WAIT 3 MONTHS

- Even if thinking of delaying pregnancy -- come in now
- Unprotected intercourse without conceiving -- see us
- Age 35 or above at time of trying
- Irregular or absent periods
- Known PCOS, endometriosis or fibroids
- Two or more previous pregnancy losses
- Genetic condition in either partner's family
- Partner has a known fertility concern

## WHAT YOUR PRECONCEPTION CONSULTATION AT RENEW HEALTHCARE COVERS

A preconception consultation at Renew Healthcare is a structured 45-60 minute appointment for both partners together. We take a full medical and reproductive history, review all current medications, and assess lifestyle factors for each of you individually. Investigations are recommended based on your specific profile -- not a standard panel applied to everyone.

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